

Episode 43: Almost the End! *Hakaba Kitaro* – Stories of Tokyo from My Early Childhood

Spring in March. March means the annual JR schedule revision!

I'm not particularly a "train otaku," but when I see the thick timetable covers at bookstores with "Schedule Revision" written on them, I get inexplicably happy. Don't you all feel somewhat excited too? Don't you feel like taking a train trip somewhere? ...Huh? That's strange.

Actually, in conjunction with this weekend's schedule revision on the 15th, "Passnet Cards" will no longer be usable. Did you all know this?

"Passnet Cards" are prepaid cards that let you ride almost all the private railway lines in the Tokyo metropolitan area with just one card, without buying tickets. When they first appeared, I was overjoyed and used them daily, but with the arrival of SUICA and PASMO, which can be used for both private railways and JR East, I've become completely a SUICA person now.

So I'm currently desperately trying to use up the unused Passnet cards I have left. When I say "use up," there's really only my daily commute to use them for, so no matter how hard I try, I can't use them all up. Even if some are left over, I can still use them at vending machines to buy tickets for a while, or get refunds at ticket windows.

Still, Passnet cards have been very helpful to me. Out of respect, I thought I'd try to use them to the end.

So despite the warm weather being perfect for cycling, I'm faithfully taking the train to work (bitter laugh).

Well then.

Hakaba Kitaro, currently airing to great acclaim, now has only 2 episodes left.

After watching last week's episode 9, my wife asked a simple question (sorry for the slight spoiler...): "Kitaro was dissolved for 3 years? So the next one is 3 years later?" Well, it's not strictly a story from 3 years later, but after episode 9, some time passes, and this week's episode 10 "Brigadoon" is set just before the Tokyo Olympics. So it's a story from around 1962-1963. Right around when I was born (laugh).

One thing I was happy about participating in *Hakaba Kitaro* was being able to visualise old Tokyo scenes and lifestyles. The setting for anime *Hakaba Kitaro* is Tokyo during roughly 10 years from the end of the 1940s, a little after the end of the Pacific War, through around 1964 when Tokyo was excited about the Olympics.

I was born in April 1963. I'm Tokyo-born and Tokyo-raised. A true Tokyo native, a Nakano native (laugh). The following autumn, the Tokaido Shinkansen began service, and on October 10th, the Tokyo Olympics opened. I heard that my mother took me, still one year old, to watch the Olympic torch relay run down Ome Kaido. I naturally have no memory of that or of the Tokyo Olympics themselves, but the atmosphere of that time remained vivid until I was about 4.

The alley in front of our house was an unpaved dirt road that got muddy after rain. Along the roadside were ditches covered only with boards—what we called "dobu" (laugh)—which still existed then. Naturally, toilets were also sewage collection types. Vacuum trucks would come regularly and suck things up with a "gogogogogo" sound, which I would watch from the edge of our yard from a safe distance.

In the neighbourhood, there were exposed earth cliffs with horizontal holes that had been used as air raid shelters still remaining, sealed off so you couldn't enter.

In Shinjuku, where I often went with my parents and grandmother, the east exit had a food department store called "Niko" where Studio Alta is now, and streetcars still ran

along Yasukuni-dori. Once, on the way back from visiting Yasukuni Shrine in Kudan with my parents, I have a memory of riding a streetcar from in front of Shinjuku Shochiku (which no longer exists—it was around the Shinjuku City Hall intersection) back to Shinjuku. Shinjuku's west exit didn't have super high-rise buildings yet and was still just the former site of Yodobashi Water Purification Plant. The Chuo Line trains were still running chocolate-coloured cars with wooden floors.

For *Hakaba Kitaro* production preparation, they prepared massive amounts of books and photo data for us. There were so many things where I thought "Ah, I know this, I remember this"—it was really fun (laugh). I quite enjoyed reading, looking, and studying them. Home appliances, household goods—everything I looked at was nostalgic (laugh).

So how could we bring this atmosphere to the screen?

Actually, the *Hakaba* staff is quite young. Directors Ueda-san, Kakudo-san, Shibata-san, and Sato-san are older than me, but director Chioka, director Hatano-san, art director Kurahashi-san, assistant directors, and production staff are all young people still in their 30s and 20s. Among the colour directors too, everyone except Sakuma-san, who's my age, are young people. So the "senior group" who experientially know the atmosphere and feel of that era naturally put extra effort into obsessing over the details (laugh).

Also, in art meetings for this week's episode 10, the art director in charge knew old Shinjuku well (he's considerably older than me), and in front of period photos prepared as reference materials, the art director and I got so excited that we ignored the meeting. Director Hatano-san couldn't follow the conversation and was sweating (laugh).

I hope you can feel the obsessions of us "senior group" members, including myself, in various places throughout *Hakaba Kitaro* (laugh).

